Principles of Politics and War

A Citizen's Guide to the Contest Over the Ledger

Macharia Barii

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Abstract

This essay offers twelve principles for understanding political contest, from the smallest quarrel to the largest war. The principles are drawn from a single observation: civilization is a set of relations among people –who gives, who gains, who loses, and how that is justified. This set of relations is what the essay calls the ledger. The principles describe how the ledger is structured, how it is contested, and how it is rebalanced.

They do not tell the reader what to conclude; they tell the reader what to look at. The essay is short because it is meant to be used.

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Preface

This essay is short because it is meant to be used. It is not a treatise on political philosophy. It is a list of principles—things to look at, things to understand, things to notice—that together describe the structure of every political contest, from the smallest quarrel to the largest war. The principles are drawn from a simple observation: civilization is a set of relations among people. Who gives, who gains, who loses, and how that is justified. This set of relations is what this essay calls **the ledger**. Everything else—the institutions, the ideologies, the wars, the peace treaties—is an outcome of the ledger and the contest over it. Once you see the contest as a contest over the ledger, a great deal becomes clear that was previously mysterious. Why some conflicts are negotiated and others are fought. Why some orders last and others collapse. Why the same person can be a reformer in one context and a conservative in another. Why the claim to neutrality is always a claim made from a position. The essay offers twelve principles. They are not a list of conclusions. They are a list of things to look at. If you learn to look at them, you will see what most public debate conceals.

What the Ledger Is

Before the principles, the central term. **A ledger is the set of relations among a group of people, described by what each party contributes, what each party receives, and how the difference is justified.** Every relation can be described in five dimensions:

- **Contribution:** what each party puts in—labor, money, time, loyalty, obedience.
- **Benefit:** what each party gets out—income, security, status, protection, meaning.
- **Exit:** whether each party can leave the relation if it is unsatisfactory.
- **Voice:** whether each party can speak, criticize, organize, and renegotiate.
- **Justification:** the story that makes the relation appear natural, necessary, and just.

When the benefits exceed the costs for both parties, the relation is **symbiotic**. When one party extracts more than it gives while the other survives, the relation is **parasitic**. When one party extracts by destroying the other's capacity to survive, the relation is **predatory**.

Every civilization is a mix of all three. The question is never whether a civilization is good or bad in the abstract. The question is which relations are symbiotic, which are parasitic, which are predatory, and who occupies each position. That is the ledger. The principles that follow describe how the ledger is structured, how it is contested, and how it is rebalanced.

Part I: The Structure

1 Every Order Is a Ledger

Every human order—a family, a firm, a state, an empire—is a ledger of relations. Someone contributes labor, money, time, or loyalty. Someone receives the benefit. Someone can leave. Someone can speak. The relation has a structure: who gives, who gets, who can exit, who can voice, how long the horizon is, and how the whole is justified. The monument is not the order. The monument is the output. The order is the ledger of relations that produced it. Look at the ledger, not the monument.

2 Every Relation Has a Position

Every relation has two sides. The employer and the worker. The ruler and the ruled. The creditor and the debtor. The colonizer and the colonized. The position is the place a party occupies in the relation—what they contribute, what they receive, whether they can leave, whether they can speak. The position is not the same as the person. A good person can occupy a position that benefits them and harms others. A bad person can occupy a position that costs them and benefits others. The position is structural. The person is incidental. To understand a relation, look at the positions, not the personalities.

3 Whether a Relation Is Good or Bad Depends on Your Position

This is the first principle of all conflict. A relation is not good or bad in itself. It is good for those who benefit from it and bad for those who bear its cost. The same wage contract is good for the employer and bad for the worker. The same tax is good for the beneficiary and bad for the payer. The same border is good for those inside and bad for those outside. There is no neutral position from which to evaluate the relation, because every evaluation is made from a position. The person who claims to evaluate from nowhere is either occupying a position they do not acknowledge or speaking for a coalition they do not name. The claim to neutrality is itself a position.

4 Those Who Benefit Defend; Those Who Bear the Cost Attack

Once you see the principle of position, the engine of conflict becomes visible. Those who benefit from the current arrangement defend it. Those who bear the cost attack it. Both are responding rationally to their position. The beneficiary defends with arguments, with institutions, with legitimacy regimes, and—when necessary—with force. The cost-bearer attacks with arguments, with organizing, with resistance, and—when necessary—with force. Neither is wicked. Both

are positioned. The conflict is not about values. It is about positions. The values are the vocabulary; the positions are the substance.

Part II: The Contest

5 Politics and War Are the Same Contest, Judged by Different Means

Politics and war are not opposites. They are the same contest—the contest over the ledger—judged by different means. Politics is the peaceful contest. The parties disagree about the terms of the relation, and they contest those terms through institutions: elections, courts, legislatures, bargaining, protest, organizing. The contest is peaceful because the parties believe the institutions can produce an outcome they can accept. War is the violent contest. The parties disagree about the terms of the relation, and they contest those terms through force. The contest is violent because the parties no longer believe the institutions can produce an acceptable outcome. The difference is not the nature of the contest. It is the mechanism of judgment. Politics uses institutions to judge who benefits and who bears the cost. War uses force to judge the same question. Both are judges. Both produce verdicts. Both allocate the ledger. This is why politics has all the characteristics of war. The coalitions, the strategies, the costs, the stakes—they are the same in politics as in war. The difference is that politics is conducted under rules that both sides believe will bind. When the rules stop binding, politics descends to war. The descent is not a departure from politics. It is politics continuing by other means, because the political means have failed.

6 Entrenchment Leads to War; Negotiability Leads to Politics

The choice between politics and war is not a choice the parties make. It is a choice the structure makes for them. If positions and outcomes are entrenched—if the parties believe the current arrangement cannot be changed through the available institutions—then war is the likely judge. The beneficiaries have locked in their advantage. The cost-bearers have no path to redress. Politics becomes a ritual that reproduces the status quo. The cost-bearers conclude that the only path to change is force. If positions and outcomes are negotiable—if the parties believe the current

arrangement can be changed through the available institutions—then politics is the likely judge. The beneficiaries are willing to make concessions. The cost-bearers have a path to redress. Politics becomes a genuine contest, and the cost-bearers have reason to pursue their claims through institutions rather than through force. The conditions that make politics possible are the conditions that make the order negotiable: equal exit costs, expanded voice, a broad selectorate, a long time horizon. The conditions that make war likely are the conditions that entrench the positions: asymmetric exit costs, concentrated voice, a narrow selectorate, a short time horizon. The reform of the structure matters more than the persuasion of the parties. You cannot persuade an entrenched coalition to accept a negotiation it believes it will lose. You can only change the structure so that the negotiation is possible.

7 The Justification Comes After the Verdict

The standard story presents the order as justified first and established second: the parties agree on the principles, and then they build the institutions. The framework says: the parties contest the ledger, the contest is judged by politics or by war, the verdict allocates the ledger, and then the justification is created to make the verdict appear natural. This is why every legitimacy regime has a retrospective quality. It is the verdict's memory, dressed as the verdict's cause. The divine right of kings was created after the conquest. The Mandate of Heaven was created after the war. The racial hierarchy was created after the colonization. In each case, the verdict came first, and the justification came after. The implication is that the justification can always be contested by returning to the verdict. If you want to challenge a legitimacy regime, you do not argue with its principles. You return to the verdict that produced it—the conquest, the seizure, the first allocation—and you ask: who won, who lost, and on what basis? The justification cannot survive the return, because the justification is designed to conceal the verdict, and the return exposes it.

Part III: The Rebalancing

8 The Justice Mechanism Rebalances the Drift

Every order drifts out of balance over time. The concentration of wealth, the decay of legitimacy, the accumulation of grievance—these are the drift. The question is how the order rebalances. The justice mechanism—courts, elections, redistribution, reform, revolution, war—reduces the injustice gap when the gap becomes too wide. It operates on the accepted order, not on the first allocation. It adjusts the drift from the verdict, not the verdict itself. This is why the justice mechanism is always partial. It can make the order less unjust without making it just. The verdict remains; the drift is corrected. The result is a new equilibrium, but not a new foundation.

9 Institutional Justice Adjusts; Revolutionary Justice Replaces

There are two kinds of justice mechanisms, and they do different things. Institutional justice—courts, elections, redistribution, reform—adjusts the drift. It accepts the verdict as given and rebalances the distribution that the verdict produced. It is cheap, incremental, and preserves the foundation. Revolutionary justice—revolution, war, collapse—re-judges the verdict. It does not accept the verdict as given; it contests the foundation itself. It is costly, radical, and replaces the foundation. The choice between them is determined by the structure. If the drift can be adjusted, the institutional mechanism operates. If the drift cannot be adjusted, the revolutionary mechanism operates. The first is preferable when it is possible. The second is inevitable when the first is not.

10 The Cost of Adjustment Is Borne by Those Who Cannot Leave

When the order rebalances, someone bears the cost. In an institutional adjustment, the cost is shared—through taxation, redistribution, and reform. In a collapse, the cost is borne by the population—through famine, war, displacement, and death. The coalition is protected by its resources, its mobility, and its access to the state. The population is exposed by its immobility, its dependence, and its exclusion. The asymmetry of exposure is the deepest structural fact of any order. Look at who pays when the order adjusts. That tells you whose capacity the order is willing to consume.

Part IV: The Judgment

11 There Is No View from Nowhere

The framework can describe the whole ledger—all the relations, all the parties, all the shares, all the exit costs, all the voice. But the description is always made from a position. There is no view from nowhere. The analyst who describes the whole is occupying the position of the analyst—the position of the person who has chosen to see the whole rather than the part. That choice is itself a position. It is not neutral, because there is no neutral position. It is *structural*, and the structural view is always taken from somewhere, even when it describes the whole. This is the framework's honesty. It does not claim to be neutral. It claims to be structural. And the structural view is always a positioned view—a view that knows it is a view, and that knows the position from which it is taken.

12 The Question Is Always the Same

The question is not "is this order just?" The question is "just for whom?" The answer is always the same: just for those who benefit, unjust for those who bear the cost. The question is not answered by the framework. It is made possible by the framework. The question is: *whose ledger is this, and for whom?* The answer depends on the position. And the position is a fact about the ledger, not a choice about morality. The framework does not resolve the contest. It makes the contest visible as a contest—not as a dispute between truth and error, but as a contest between positions in a structure.

The Whole

These twelve principles describe the structure of every political contest. **The structure** is the ledger of relations: who gives, who gets, who can leave, who can speak, how long the horizon is, how the whole is justified. **The engine** is the position: whether a relation is good or bad depends on where you stand in it. Those who benefit defend; those who bear the cost attack. **The contest** is the same whether conducted through politics or through war. The difference is the judge. Politics uses institutions; war uses force. Both produce verdicts; both allocate the ledger. **The condition** that determines which judge operates is the structure: entrenchment leads to war, negotiability leads to politics. The reform of the structure matters more than the

persuasion of the parties. **The justification** comes after the verdict. It is the residue of the contest, not its cause. It can always be contested by returning to the verdict that produced it. **The rebalancing** is the justice mechanism: it reduces the drift when the drift becomes too wide. It can be institutional (adjusting the drift) or revolutionary (replacing the foundation). The cost of the rebalancing is borne by those who cannot leave. **The judgment** is not neutral. There is no view from nowhere. The structural view is always a positioned view. But the structural view can see the whole, and seeing the whole is the first step toward changing it. **The question** is always the same: *whose ledger is this, and for whom?*

A Final Word

This essay is not a theory of politics and war. It is a discipline of attention. It tells you what to look at, what to ask, and what to notice. It

does not tell you what to conclude, because the conclusion depends on your position—and your position is a fact you must discover, not a conclusion you must accept. The principles are not a program. They are a set of questions. If you learn to ask them of every order you encounter—your government, your employer, your community, your family, and yourself—you will see what most public debate conceals. You will see the coalition behind the voter, the extraction behind the monument, the gap between the claim and the reality, the asymmetry of exit and voice, the adjustment that is paid for by the population, the justification that comes after the verdict. And you will be able to ask the question that every order must answer, and that most orders conceal: *Whose ledger is this, and for whom?* The question is not answered by the essay. It is made possible by the essay. The answer is the work of those who ask it. That is what these principles are for. Not to tell you what to think, but to show you what to look at. The rest is up to you.